



FREE SCORECARD · FOR LAS VEGAS BUSINESS OWNERS

The Las Vegas Employer's Back-Office Scorecard

The Nevada payroll rules the national playbooks get wrong, the tax credit most tipped businesses never claim, and a 12-point self-audit that shows exactly where your back office is leaking time and money.





START HERE

You built a business. The back office **built itself.**

Payroll got set up in a hurry years ago. HR lives in a group text. Compliance is a guess that has worked so far. Nobody plans it that way, it just accumulates while you run the actual business, and in Las Vegas the accumulation is riskier than most owners realize.

Nevada plays by different rules than the national franchise manuals assume, especially for anyone with tipped staff. This scorecard shows you the specific places where Vegas businesses leak money, then hands you a 12-point audit you can run on your own operation in ten minutes. **No product pitch lives inside these pages.** Just the checklist we wish every owner ran before something expensive found them first.

Who this is for: restaurants, bars, salons, spas, trades, professional services, any Las Vegas operation from a team of 2 to a team of 50 where the owner still touches payroll, benefits, or HR personally.

What's inside

- ✓ **The Vegas payroll trap** that generates back-wage findings against tipped businesses
- ✓ **The FICA tip credit**, the legitimate federal credit many eligible operators never claim
- ✓ **The real cost of DIY HR** in owner-hours, with the numbers
- ✓ **The benefits and retention math** for small teams competing with the Strip
- ✓ **The 12-point scorecard** with scoring bands and what your score means
- ✓ **What one conversation covers** through the ProtectHealth + Paychex partnership

THE VEGAS TRAP

Nevada has **no tip credit**. Your manual might not know.

The national playbook says tipped employees can be paid a reduced cash wage, federally as low as \$2.13 an hour, with tips making up the difference. **Nevada does not allow that.** Every tipped employee in the state must receive full Nevada minimum wage from the employer before a single tip counts. No exceptions, no phase-ins.

	National playbook assumption	Nevada reality
Tipped cash wage	Reduced wage allowed, tips fill the gap	Full state minimum wage, always, tips on top
Tip pooling	Varies by state	Allowed among customarily tipped employees, with strict limits on who can share
Service charges	Often treated like tips	Not tips. They are business revenue, taxed differently, and commonly mishandled

Why this page pays for the whole document: a payroll setup imported from a franchise manual or an out-of-state operator quietly builds back-wage exposure every single pay period. Findings compound, and they surface at the worst times: an audit, a departing employee's complaint, a sale of the business. If your payroll provider has never once mentioned Nevada's tip rules to you, that silence is information.

The fix is not dramatic. It is one competent review of how tipped hours, pooling, and service charges flow through your payroll, by someone who works in Nevada rules daily.



THE MISSED MONEY

The federal credit tipped businesses forget to claim

Here is the flip side of Nevada's strict tip rules, and it is good news. Employers pay FICA taxes on the tips their employees report. The federal FICA tip credit, claimed on IRS Form 8846, lets eligible food and beverage businesses claim a dollar-for-dollar credit for much of that employer-side tax.

7.65%

Employer-side FICA rate paid on reported tips, the money the credit targets.

FICA: 6.2% Social Security + 1.45% Medicare

\$1000s

What the credit is commonly worth per year to a tip-heavy Las Vegas operation, compounding every year it goes unclaimed.

Varies with tip volume; a tax professional runs your number

Illustrative example: a bar with \$400,000 in reported tips annually

Employer FICA paid on those tips vs the credit-eligible share (illustrative, actual figures vary by wage detail)



The honest fine print: eligibility rules are specific, the math interacts with minimum-wage tests, and this credit belongs on a tax professional's desk, not a brochure. ProtectHealth brokers are insurance nerds, not tax professionals. What we do is flag the question, connect the payroll data through the Paychex partnership so the reporting is clean, and make sure your CPA has what they need to claim what you have earned.

If nobody has ever mentioned Form 8846 to you and you run a tipped business, put a checkmark next to question 6 on the scorecard, and ask your tax professional this quarter, not next year.



THE HIDDEN INVOICE

DIY HR sends you an invoice every month. It's your calendar.

The back office never bills you directly. It bills you in Sunday afternoons running payroll, in 9pm compliance Googling, in the hiring push you postponed because onboarding paperwork ate the week. The research on small employers puts numbers on that invoice:

70%

Of small business owners spend more than a week per month on HR administration alone.

Source: OEM America small business research

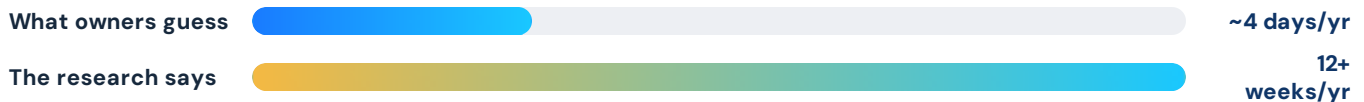
51%

Say compliance burdens have negatively impacted their company's growth.

Source: OEM America small business research

A week+ per month, compounded over a year

Owner-time spent on HR admin at the 70% finding, versus what most owners would guess



Twelve-plus weeks is not administration, it is a second unpaid job, and it is the highest-value time in the company because it belongs to the person who could otherwise be growing revenue. The scorecard on page 7 will tell you exactly how much of that invoice your operation is paying.

The Vegas multiplier: hospitality-adjacent businesses run nights, weekends, and holidays, which means the back-office work lands on the only hours the owner had left. The Strip never sleeps, and neither does its paperwork.

THE KEEP-YOUR-PEOPLE MATH

In this town, your best cook has offers.

Las Vegas small businesses compete for staff against Strip properties with full benefits packages. You will not out-benefits a casino, and you do not have to. Retention math for small teams works differently: people stay for a package that says the owner thought about them, plus the schedule flexibility and closeness a small operation genuinely offers.

What small teams can realistically offer	Why it moves retention
Health coverage access	The single most-requested benefit. Structures now exist at small-team scale that did not five years ago, including defined-contribution approaches.
A real retirement option	Increasingly expected, and increasingly supported by state-level mandates and simplified small-employer plans nationwide.
Clean payroll, on time, every time	Nothing erodes trust faster than a wrong paycheck. Accuracy is a retention benefit nobody lists on job posts.
A handbook and fair process	People stay where the rules are written down and applied evenly. It also happens to be your compliance armor.

The replacement-cost lens: industry estimates for replacing an hourly employee routinely run into the thousands per departure once hiring, training, and lost productivity are counted. A modest benefits package priced against three preventable departures a year usually wins the math, before counting the hiring ads you stop running.



RUN THE AUDIT

The 12-point scorecard. Check every box that's true.

✓	Statement	Area
☐	Every tipped employee receives full Nevada minimum wage before tips, verified in the last 12 months.	Payroll
☐	Service charges and tips are separated correctly in our books and on pay stubs.	Payroll
☐	Our tip pool has been checked against Nevada rules on who may legally share.	Compliance
☐	Payroll taxes file on time, every time, without me personally touching them.	Payroll
☐	We know whether we qualify for the FICA tip credit, and claim it if we do.	Tax
☐	A current employee handbook exists, and every hire signs it.	HR
☐	Onboarding paperwork (I-9, W-4, state notices) is complete and stored for every employee.	HR
☐	Workers' comp coverage matches our actual current headcount and job classifications.	Compliance
☐	We could survive a labor audit tomorrow without a weekend of panic-assembly.	Compliance
☐	We offer, or have seriously priced, health coverage access for the team.	Benefits
☐	We offer, or have seriously priced, a retirement option.	Benefits
☐	I spend less than one day per month personally on payroll, HR, and compliance combined.	Owner time

10-12 checked

Tight ship. Keep the annual review habit. The conversation worth having is benefits optimization and growth.

6-9 checked

Normal, and leaking. Two or three of the unchecked boxes are costing real money or real hours right now.

5 or fewer checked

The back office is running you. Nothing here is unfixable, and none of it fixes itself. One structured conversation puts the fixes in order of what is bleeding most.

THE FIX

Why one conversation now covers the whole picture

ProtectHealth has officially partnered with Paychex, one of the nation's largest payroll and HR companies. That partnership exists for exactly the situation this scorecard describes: a Las Vegas owner staring at four unchecked boxes across payroll, HR, compliance, and benefits, who does not want four vendors and four sales calls to fix them.

How it works	What it means for you
ProtectHealth brings the strategy	Local Las Vegas brokers who map your benefits picture the same strategy—first way we handle every client: your business first, products second.
Paychex brings the machinery	Payroll built for Nevada's rules, HR infrastructure, compliance support, and retirement options, at a scale a small business could never build alone.
You get handed to a person	No brochure funnels. When payroll or HR goes deeper, you are personally connected to our dedicated Paychex team, and you always know who you are talking to and why.

The win condition, in writing: **a genuine advisor conversation, not a sales appointment.** If your scorecard came back 11 out of 12 and the honest answer is that you only need one small fix, that is exactly what you will hear. The businesses that need more get the whole picture handled through one relationship instead of five.

Bring your scorecard. Owners who show up with the 12 boxes marked get a sharper conversation. We start with the unchecked ones, in order of expense.



YOUR NEXT 20 MINUTES

You just audited your back office in ten minutes. Now fix it in one conversation.

One free employer strategy conversation. Bring your scorecard, or just bring what the employer side of your business feels like right now. A ProtectHealth broker walks the unchecked boxes in order of what is bleeding most, and if payroll or HR should go deeper, connects you personally to our dedicated Paychex team. If your house is already in order, you will hear that too.

Book at protecthealth.com/employers

Or call **800-240-8185** · 2915 W Charleston Blvd Ste 170, Las Vegas

★★★★★ 4.9 from 703+ Google reviews from Las Vegas businesses and families.

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